

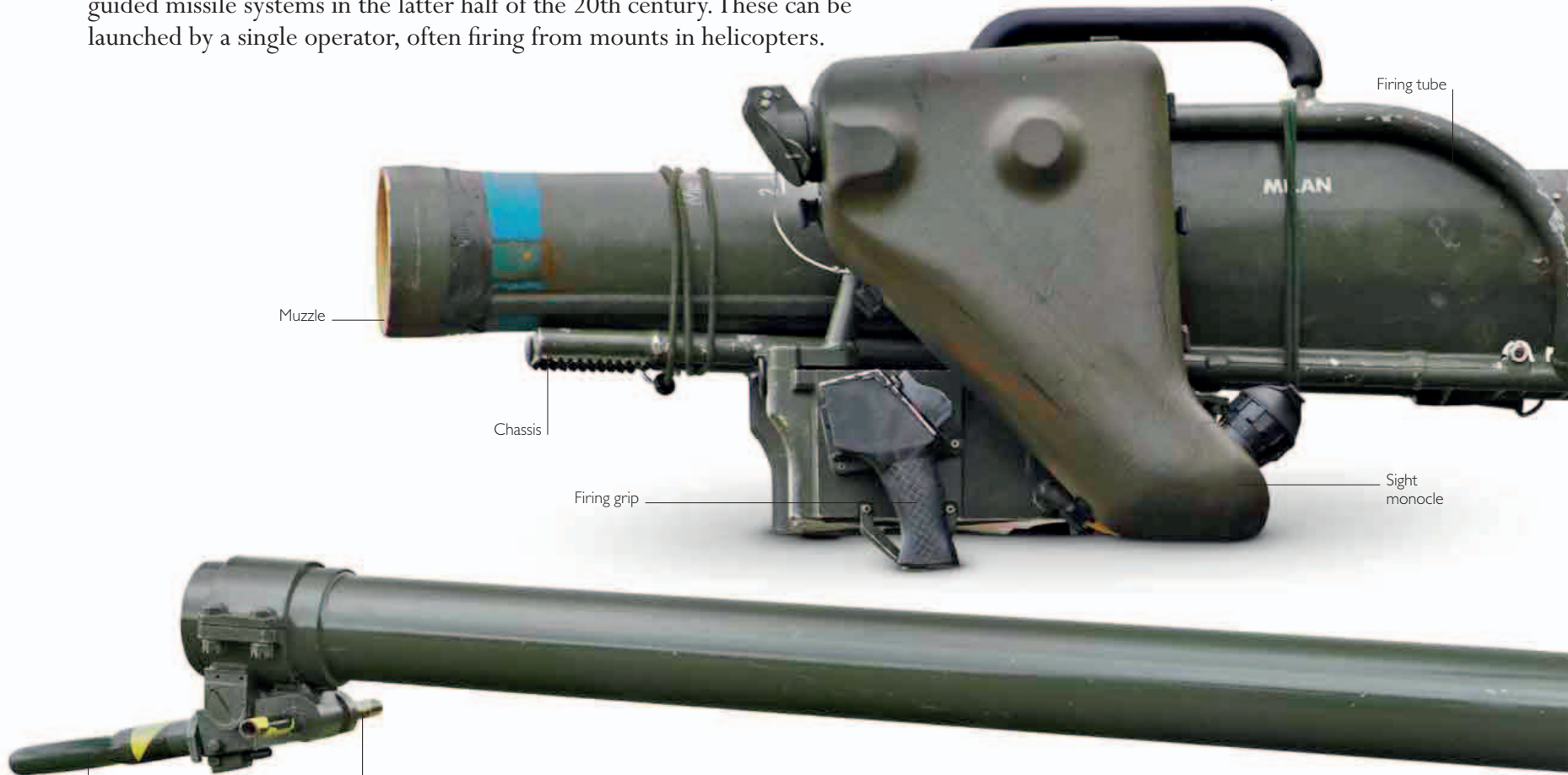
RECOIL-LESS ANTITANK WEAPONS

Antitank weapons have diversified since the World Wars. Developed in the 1930s, the recoil-less rifle has evolved into the towed and handheld types seen today. It is a lightweight artillery weapon that diverts the exhaust gases of the propellant backward to counteract the recoil of a gun. Gun carriages for it were designed to face forward, toward the barrel. The next major development after the recoil-less rifle has been the creation of portable guided missile systems in the latter half of the 20th century. These can be launched by a single operator, often firing from mounts in helicopters.

▼ MILAN ANTITANK MISSILE LAUNCHER

Date	1972
Origin	France, West Germany
Length	4ft (1.2m)
Caliber	125mm
Range	1¼ miles (1.95km)

The *Missile d'Infanterie Léger Antichar*, or MILAN, is an antitank guided missile that is directed to its target via signals sent along wires that reel out behind it as it flies. Seen here is its launcher. Although many MILANs are vehicle-mounted, they can be deployed by a two-man infantry crew.



▲ L4 MOBAT

Date	1950s
Origin	UK
Length	8¾ft (2.7m)
Caliber	120mm
Range	½ mile (800m)

The 1950s saw the creation of the WOMBAT (Weapon of Magnesium Battalion, AntiTank), a British recoil-less rifle operated by a crew of three. The L6 WOMBAT's shield was removed to produce the L4 MOBAT (Mobile Battalion, AntiTank). This weapon was much lighter, and it was designed to be towed by a specially adapted Land Rover.